



OFF-CURRICULUM

The Starter Collection.

*Seven notes on the mind, the patterns underneath,
and the old wisdom that still applies.*

TARANAUJLA.CA



BY TARAN AUJLA

Seven essays · 2026 edition

TARANAUJLA.CA

A NOTE BEFORE YOU START

Welcome.

Welcome, and thanks for being here.

These seven notes are part of an ongoing series called *Off-Curriculum*. Short pieces I write when something I have been sitting with finally lands in a form I can put down. They are not advice. They are not a system. They are just the working notes of one man trying to live a bit more deliberately than the script most of us were handed.

I chose these seven because together they read as a beginning. They set up a way of thinking the rest of the writing on the site builds on. Read them in order if you want, or skip around. There is no test at the end.

From now on, when a new note lands on the site, I will send it to you by email. No schedule. No filler. Only when there is something worth sending.

If at any point the writing stops landing for you, the unsubscribe link at the bottom of every email works. I will not take it personally. The reader and the writer have to be on the same page or neither one is reading.

Easy does it. One day at a time.

— *Taran*

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NO. 01 OF 7

Watch Your *Thoughts*.

On the discovery that the voice in our head isn't actually us.

Sit somewhere quiet for two minutes and try not to think.

Within seconds, the mind starts. The conversation from yesterday, the thing we forgot to do, the email we need to answer, the "to-do" list...the thoughts just arrive, on their own, uninvited, and we follow them down whatever rabbit hole they want to take us.

We don't choose them. We just obey them.

And here's the part most of us never stop to notice: we treat whatever the mind says as if it's true. If the thought says *you're not enough*, we feel not enough. If it says *this is going to go wrong, or is going to be hard*, we expect it to go that way. The thought arrives, we take it as fact, and we move through the day on it.

It's wild when you stop and think about it. We let a voice we never even hired make most of the decisions in our heads.

The Stoics figured this out a long time ago.

Marcus Aurelius (who was the emperor of Rome, not someone with a lot of free time on his hands) kept a private notebook where, on every page basically, he reminded himself:

The soul becomes dyed with the color of its thoughts.

MARCUS AURELIUS · MEDITATIONS, BOOK V.16 · C. AD 170

He had to write that down. Not because it was a new idea, but because forgetting it was the default. Even for him.

James Allen, centuries later, put the same idea this way:

As he thinks, so he is; as he continues to think, so he remains.

JAMES ALLEN · AS A MAN THINKETH · 1903

Not a thought once. The thoughts we continue to think. Over years, the repetition wins.

Both of them were pointing at the same thing. The thoughts running through our heads matter more than almost anything else we're going to do today.

So...who's choosing them?

Here's the move I came across that actually changed things for me.

We don't have to argue with the thought. We don't have to fight it. We don't have to replace it with a "positive" one.

We just notice it.

A thought arrives, anxious or comparing or replaying something or judging ourselves or catastrophizing about Tuesday, and we name it quietly, just to ourselves. *Anxious thought. Comparison thought. Replaying thought.*

That's it. That's the whole move. Detach from it, almost robotically. Snap out of it the moment you notice it.

Something quiet happens the first time we actually do this. The thought gets smaller. Not because we wrestled with it. Because being seen, for most thoughts, is the end of their power. They've been running on the assumption that they're us. The moment we watch one happening, instead of being inside it, it loosens. We're suddenly the one watching, not the one being moved.

This isn't positive thinking. It isn't the "good vibes only" thing.

Positive thinking is the move where we fight the dark thought and try to replace it with a sunnier one. That doesn't work for long, because the dark thought always comes back, and we spend our lives in a tug of war we can't actually win.

The work is more honest than that. We see the thought, we name it, we ask quietly: is this actually true? Most of the time, looked at directly, it isn't. The catastrophe the mind is rehearsing hasn't happened. The verdict it's delivering on us is based on some belief installed years ago that we've never actually examined. The comparison it's running between us and someone else is selective and unfair to both of us.

We don't have to win against the thoughts. We just have to stop assuming they're telling us the truth.

The thing nobody told us:

We're not our thoughts.

We're the ones watching them.

That shift, kept up day by day, makes almost everything else lighter.

TARAN · ONTARIO, CANADA

NO. 02 OF 7

The Script We Were *Handed.*

On the life most of us are living that we never really chose.

Most of us are not actually living the lives we chose.

That sounds dramatic when you read it the first time...it isn't, really. It's just the math.

By the time we were old enough to think about what kind of life we wanted, we had already absorbed thirty thousand opinions about what a good life looked like. From parents, teachers, neighbours, the kids we grew up next to, movies, commercials, the whole machinery of family and school and culture running in the background of every childhood.

By the time we noticed any of it, if we ever did, it had been running for decades and was indistinguishable from our own thinking.

That's the script.

The script doesn't feel like a script when we're inside it. It feels like life. Like the natural order of things. Like a series of choices we're making, freshly, every day.

Most of those choices are not actually fresh. They're the script running, again, the way it has been running for years. We do the thing we were going to do anyway, and we tell ourselves we chose it.

This is what *autopilot* actually means. Not the daydreaming-while-driving sense. The deeper one. Living a life shaped by rules we did not write, beliefs we don't really question, taking in things we did not select, sprinting toward outcomes we never stopped long enough to decide on. *Do I really want or need this? And why?*

The strange part is that the autopilot life can look completely fine from the outside. Some of them look enviable. The cost is something quieter. It shows up in the gap between what's happening and what would have been happening if we had been paying attention and chose differently. The conversation we did not have because the script did not leave room for it. The decade we spent climbing a ladder because we'd been told the climb was the point (or because that's what everyone does), and the question of whether we wanted to be at the top of that particular ladder did not surface until the climb was nearly done. Once on top, looking down and thinking, perhaps this ladder was leaning against the wrong wall...by then it's almost too late.

In 1845, Thoreau walked into the woods, lived in a small cabin he built himself, and stayed for two years. He wrote a book about it. The most quoted line from that book is the one we should sit with the longest:

The mass of men lead lives of quiet desperation.

HENRY DAVID THOREAU · WALDEN, "ECONOMY" · 1854

He wasn't being mean about it when he wrote that. He was being honest. Most people, he was observing, were living lives they hadn't really chosen, on terms they hadn't really set, hoping somewhere along the way it would start to feel like theirs. It usually didn't.

His own words for why he went:

I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived.

HENRY DAVID THOREAU · WALDEN, "WHERE I LIVED, AND WHAT I LIVED FOR" · 1854

He didn't go to escape. He went to find out what was actually his, underneath everything that had been handed to him. Separate from all the external, material people, places, things.

You don't have to go to the woods.

You don't have to quit your job, leave your city, or throw out the script. The script is not going anywhere. It's been running for decades, and it knows how to argue for itself. What you can do is start watching it. The same way we noticed thoughts in the last piece. Without arguing. Without trying to win.

Notice the assumption you don't remember choosing. Notice the ambition that doesn't actually belong to you. Notice the thing you keep telling yourself you want because you've been told you should want it. Notice the version of yourself you've been performing.

Most people who actually shift their lives don't do it by throwing everything out. They do it by stepping back, getting better at seeing what's running, day by day, and choosing where to push back.

The script keeps running. That's the point.

We don't get free of it. We get the ability to see it and choose against it, when we want to, again and again, with increasing speed.

TARAN · ONTARIO, CANADA

NO. 03 OF 7

Don't Death Grip the Outcome.

On doing the thing, trusting the process, and the cost of needing the outcome.

There's a strange pattern that shows up in almost every domain of high performance.

The harder you grip the outcome, the worse you tend to do.

Watch any negotiating table. The person who needs the deal too badly does not walk out with the best terms. They walk out with terms a calmer person could have done better than. Watch any athlete. The one overthinking the shot misses it. The one playing for fun, in the moment, drains it. Watch anyone trying to force a difficult conversation to go a particular way. It almost always goes a worse direction than if they had relaxed into it.

It's strange when you stop and notice it...but the harder we want something specific to happen, the more we tend to mess up the very actions that would have made it happen.

This is the effort paradox.

The ancients figured this out a long time ago.

The *Bhagavad Gita*, written roughly twenty-five hundred years ago, has Krishna telling Arjuna something that has carried into almost every serious tradition of thought since:

You have the right to work, but never to the fruit of work.

BHAGAVAD GITA 2.47 · EASWARAN TRANSLATION · C. 5TH CENTURY BCE

That line does a lot of work in not very many words. Your right, your business, the only thing you actually control...is the action. Not the result. Not the praise or the reward or the score or the recognition. Those happen outside you. You don't make them happen by gripping them harder. You make them happen, when they happen at all, by doing the work the moment in front of you actually requires.

The Stoics arrived at the same place from the other side of the world a few centuries later. Epictetus, who had been born into slavery and ended up teaching philosophy, opened his manual with this line:

Some things are in our control, and others not.

EPICETUS · ENCHIRIDION 1.1 · C. AD 125

Within our control: our actions, our judgments, the standard we hold ourselves to. Not in our control: the outcome, the other person's response, the timeline, the body, the market, the weather. The first column is what we work on. The second column is what we accept as it comes.

We can do our part. We cannot make the rest happen.

Here's the part most of us miss.

When we're gripping the outcome, we're not really doing the action. We're somewhere else. Running the result in our heads, replaying what we want, projecting forward into the moment we get the thing. We're bracing, stressing, acting from fear of not getting it. And fear-based performance is, almost always, worse performance.

This shows up everywhere. On a deal table. On a tennis court. In the middle of a difficult conversation with someone we love. In the slow work of getting healthy again, or building a business, or writing something, or raising kids. The gripped version of us is acting from worry. The relaxed version is acting from presence. Presence wins the round, almost every time.

The practice itself is small.

Do the next thing in front of you, the one that moves you toward where you want to go (this part matters; you can't be doing the opposite and expect to get there). Then do the next one. Then the next. Daily. The actions compound, quietly, in a way you cannot really watch in real time, and one day you look up and the thing has happened, or something better than the thing has happened. It didn't look like a moment. It looked like a thousand small actions you mostly forgot you were doing.

The way to make this stick is to actually stop watching the scoreboard for a while. Do the work for the work, and let where it lands land. It takes some faith. Not the religious kind. A quiet faith in the process itself, and in the belief that consistent daily action will eventually produce its own results.

The grip is what was costing you. Loosening it is the actual move.

You don't have to stop caring. You just have to stop needing.

Do the thing.

Don't grip the outcome.

Take it easy.

Effort without attachment. Action without desperation.

TARAN · ONTARIO, CANADA

The Way That Doesn't *Force.*

On wu wei, releasing the grip, and the kind of action that actually moves things.

Some of the worst stretches of my life had the same cause.

I was forcing something. A deal that wasn't moving. A version of life I had pictured and was determined to make happen. A result I needed by a certain date. In each case, I doubled down. I pushed harder. I gripped tighter. The harder I gripped, the further the thing seemed to move from me. The harder I pushed, the more resistance I generated. I told myself this was discipline. It wasn't. It was forcing.

The shift came when I stopped.

Not stopped caring. Not stopped working. Stopped forcing. I let the day be what it was. I worked with what was actually in front of me rather than what I wanted to be in front of me. I stopped trying to bend the outside world to match the picture in my head and started responding to the world as it actually was. The pressure dropped. The work got easier. And the things I had been forcing started to move on their own.

The Taoists named this two and a half thousand years ago. The phrase is *wu wei*. It is often translated as "non-action" or "non-doing," but the more careful rendering is "not acting from constructs," meaning not acting from

the picture we have built in our heads about how things should be. Wu wei is the practice of dropping the constructed picture and responding to the actual situation.

Lao Tzu wrote, in the chapter Chad Hansen titles "Primitive Lack of Desire":

Ways fix on not acting from constructs.

LAO TZU · TAO TE CHING, CHAPTER 37 · CHAD HANSEN TRANSLATION

The line sounds dense, but it is practical. The natural unfolding of things, what Lao Tzu calls the Way, is committed to not acting from the constructs we build. Most of our suffering comes from acting on those constructs. The picture we have built. The result we have already decided is the right one. The shape the day should take. When we release the construct, the resistance drops, and the situation moves.

The image Lao Tzu returns to most often is water. Water does not force its way. It flows around obstacles. It finds the lowest path. And given enough time, water wears down stone. The hardest thing in any landscape gives way to the softest. Not because the softest is stronger. Because the softest is not trying.

Here is what gets clear when we start to practice this.

The things we have been trying hardest to make happen are usually the things we have been trying hardest to control. The control is the obstacle. We are creating the very resistance we are then trying to push through. The deal we cannot close is the deal we are gripping. The relationship that will not bend is the relationship we are trying to bend. The result that will not arrive is the result we have been demanding instead of building toward.

Releasing the grip is not surrender in the weak sense. It is not giving up. It is letting the situation be what it is, doing the next right action, and trusting that consistent action without forcing is what actually moves things over time.

The two pieces I have written on this site, *Don't Death Grip the Outcome* and *Playing Not to Lose*, are both pointing at the same thing from different angles. One is about gripping the result. The other is about gripping what we already have out of fear. Both are forms of force. Both are obstacles disguised as commitment. The move underneath both is the same one Lao Tzu was pointing at twenty-five hundred years ago.

Stop forcing.

Do the next right thing.

Move with the current.

Let the work do what it does.

That is the move.

TARAN · ONTARIO, CANADA

NO. 05 OF 7

Being Carried.

On the quiet presence that arrives when there is nothing left of us to push.

There is a thing most of us cannot say in serious company, but most of us have felt at least once.

Something carries us when we cannot carry ourselves. We do not always notice it...sometimes we only see it looking back, in the quiet of a different season. The way calm arrived when we had stopped reaching for it. The way the strength to keep moving was not, in the end, our strength. The way the worst night did not break us, even though we had no remaining force to refuse the breaking.

This is not the language of grit, motivation, or the push-through register that dominates the bookstores and the podcast feeds and the men's-development internet. That register is for people who still have something to push with. The experience this piece is naming arrives most clearly in the stretch when we have nothing left.

We are not motivated, not gritted, just emptied. And in the emptiness, something else carries the day. We come out the other side and we cannot honestly take credit for getting there.

The honest contemplative traditions have all named this. The Stoics called it Providence. The contemplative Christian tradition called it grace. The Tao Te Ching pointed at it without naming it. The Sufis call it *tawakkul*.

The Sikh tradition opens its scripture with *Ek Onkar*, which translates as *there is One*. The names are different. The encounter is the same.

What gets felt is this. Something larger holds us, especially when we cannot hold ourselves. The larger thing is what each tradition gives a name to. Most of us encounter it in our own particular vocabulary, if we encounter it at all. Some of us encounter it without any vocabulary, in the silence after the surface life has been taken apart.

Marcus Aurelius, writing in the second century to himself in his private journal, addressed it as the Universe and called the relationship with it a kind of harmony:

Everything harmonizes with me, which is harmonious to thee, O Universe. Nothing for me is too early nor too late, which is in due time for thee.

MARCUS AURELIUS · MEDITATIONS IV.23 · C. 170-180 CE · LONG TRANSLATION

He was a Roman emperor writing in Greek about a felt sense he could not push his way to. He was reminding himself, on the worst days, that what arrived had been prepared for him, and that he could trust it because he had felt the trust before.

This is not religion in the denominational sense. Many of us encountered the larger thing during the stretch when we were too exhausted to believe in any specific proposition about anything. It is not the result of belief. It is not the reward for moral effort. It does not have to be earned and it cannot be argued for in any way that will satisfy a skeptic.

It is also not the empty self-help register that uses *the universe* as a polite synonym for *what I would like to happen*. That is not what we are talking about. What we are talking about is older than that. The encounter has the

felt quality of being met, not of getting what we wanted.

After we have felt it, we walk differently. We do not stop trying. We do not become passive. We just stop carrying what was never ours to carry.

The honest version, for most of us who have lived through a hard reset, is this. There was a stretch in the middle of the collapse when we were not motivated. There was nothing to be motivated by. And yet we did not collapse. Something carried us. We did not name it at the time. We did not need to. We just knew, in some quiet part of us, that we were not alone in the dark, even though every external measure said we were.

We come out of that stretch different. We can pretend the rebuild was our willpower if we want to. Many men do. But the honest reckoning, in the quiet, says something else carried us through the part we could not have carried ourselves.

What this piece wants to say is the smallest thing it can say. Something carried us. We know it because we are here, and the strength to get here did not, in the end, come only from us.

Something carries us.

We did not summon it.

We do not have to name it to know it was there.

TARAN · ONTARIO, CANADA

NO. 06 OF 7

One Day at a *Time*.

On the practice of letting tomorrow be tomorrow, and staying with today.

Most of us are not really living today.

We're somewhere else, worrying about tomorrow, replaying yesterday, running the long list of things we still haven't done, imagining the version of life that's supposed to arrive when we finally figure it out. The body is sitting in the chair, but the mind is somewhere five years from now, in a meeting that hasn't happened yet, prepping for an outcome it can't predict.

That's the trap. We're so busy time-travelling that the actual day we have is being half-lived.

The phrase *one day at a time* sounds simple. Maybe too simple. Most of us hear it and think it's a recovery slogan, or a thing you say when life feels overwhelming, and we move past it.

The phrase is older than that. Marcus Aurelius wrote, in a notebook he kept to himself two thousand years ago:

Wipe out the imagination. Stop the pulling of the strings. Confine yourself to the present.

MARCUS AURELIUS · MEDITATIONS, BOOK VII.29 · C. AD 170

He wasn't writing a self-help book. He was reminding himself, on the kind of day that was probably objectively terrible (he was running an empire, fighting a war, and grieving), that the only place his life was actually happening was right now. Not in his imagination of what was about to go wrong. Not in his rehearsal of all the things he should have done differently. In the present moment.

The same idea shows up across the Stoics, the Buddhists, the people who developed daily-practice traditions over the last two thousand years. The present is the only unit of time we actually live in. Everything else is a story the mind is telling itself about a time that isn't here.

Here's what gets clear when we start practising this.

Most of our suffering comes from being somewhere other than now. The anxiety about tomorrow is happening in our heads, today, while the actual tomorrow goes on being whatever it's going to be without our worry. The regret about yesterday is happening in our heads, today, while the actual yesterday is gone and can't be edited. We spend a lot of our actual time being half-present in our actual lives, because we're using most of our attention to live in time zones that don't exist.

And the work, the real work, can only happen in the day we're in. The book gets written one page today. The body changes by what we put in it and how we move it today. The relationship gets better by how we show up today. The career we want is built one decision, one conversation, one action, one small follow-through today. There's no other unit of time we can actually work in.

The practice itself is small.

Wake up. Do today's piece of whatever you're building, not the whole project, not the year, not the eventual goal. Just today's piece. Be in the conversations you're in. Notice when the mind starts time-travelling and quietly bring it back. End the day having done what today could hold.

Don't carry tomorrow. Tomorrow will arrive on its own, and the version of you that handles tomorrow is the version that was rested and focused enough today. The version that spent today worrying about tomorrow is the version that will be exhausted when tomorrow gets here.

The strangest part is that the long game is built almost entirely out of these small days. Not out of any single big moment. Out of a thousand mostly-forgettable Tuesdays, lived well enough that the work got done, the people got cared for, the body got moved, the mind got fed.

A year of those is something. A decade of those is a different life.

But you can only ever be in one of them at a time.

Today is the only one you have.

One day at a time.

TARAN · ONTARIO, CANADA

NO. 07 OF 7

The Version That *Fell*.

On being misread by people who only saw us at the worst point, and the quiet cost of trying to update their picture.

Most of the people who have known us are still walking around with an outdated picture of who we are.

They saw us at a particular moment, sometimes a hard one. A loss, a stumble, a public silence after something broke. That version, the one at the worst point, is the one they kept. The work that came after was private. The change was internal. They were not there for any of it.

Most of us know this from the inside. We can feel it when we walk into a room of people from before. There is a small, particular sting in being introduced to ourselves through someone else's outdated impression. We are not who they remember. We have been working on something for a long time, and they have no way of knowing.

The first instinct is usually to correct them... to say something, to send something, to find an opportunity to update the picture. To prove that we have changed. The instinct is honest, but it almost never lands.

The reason is simple. The picture they carry of us is not really about us. It is about them, about the moment they were in when they last paid attention, about what was easier to believe than to keep updating. People are not constantly revising their files on other people. They keep the version that fits the slot.

If we try to argue with the picture, we end up confirming it. We sound defensive. We look like the version that needs them to see something. The version they remember was a version that still needed something from them. The version we have become does not. Trying to explain it puts us back in the old position.

So the move, the one that takes the longest to learn but eventually becomes obvious, is this. Let the picture stay outdated. Do not fight it. Do not perform around it. Do not stage a comeback so they can finally see. Just keep doing the work. The proof shows up on its own time, and when it does, the picture updates on its own. Or it does not, and we discover that we no longer needed it to.

Marcus Aurelius noticed something like this two thousand years ago. He was running an empire and had every excuse to spend his attention on what other people thought of him. He chose not to:

It never ceases to amaze me: we all love ourselves more than other people, but care more about their opinion than our own.

MARCUS AURELIUS · MEDITATIONS XII.4 · C. 170-180 CE · HAYS TRANSLATION

The point of his sentence is the gap. We are the only ones inside our own lives. Everyone else is reading us from outside. Their picture is partial, delayed, filtered through whatever else they were dealing with at the time they last looked. None of that is theirs to fix. None of it is ours either.

There is something else worth saying. The same is true in the other direction.

Think of the friend we lost touch with, the family member we cannot quite forgive, the colleague who let us down, the person who hurt us. The version of them we are working from is also outdated. They have been doing their own work, or not, and we are not there for any of it either. Our picture of them is just as partial and just as delayed.

That recognition cuts both ways. It frees us from caring as much about the pictures other people carry of us. It also reminds us to hold the pictures we carry of others a little more lightly.

What we get back, when we stop trying to update the picture, is the time and attention we used to spend on it. That is a lot of time and attention. The mind that used to rehearse explanations gets quiet. The energy that used to go into proving the new version was real goes back into actually building it. The proof becomes the work itself, not the announcement of it.

The people who matter eventually see it, or some of them do. The people who do not see it were not paying close enough attention to notice the rebuild anyway. Both groups end up in the right place.

If you have arrived here knowing that someone, somewhere, still has you frozen at the worst version of yourself, this is what I would say. Let them. The picture is theirs to carry. It is not yours to update. Keep doing the work. The version they last saw is already gone. The one taking the work seriously is the only one that matters.

One day at a time.

Easy does it.

Do the thing.

TARAN · ONTARIO, CANADA

THANKS FOR READING

That is the start of it.

The rest of the writing lives at **taranaujla.ca**. New notes show up there first. Then they come to your inbox.

If anything in here landed for you, share it with someone who would appreciate it. Quiet word of mouth is how this kind of writing finds the right readers.

Easy does it. One day at a time. Do the thing.

— *Taran*